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NFL Showdown Large-Field Tournament Strategy

CODY MAIN // SEP 5, 2025



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As our opponents continue to evolve and the available information improves, I believe one of the biggest remaining edges in NFL showdown is properly constructing lineups to maximize correlation while still mitigating the likelihood that those lineups are heavily duplicated by the field. To start establishing optimal roster construction theories, we can use years’ worth of primetime showdown data as our guiding light. Of course, past production DOES NOT equal future success, but it is, at minimum, a worthy thought exercise and can potentially play a major role in our decision-making process on future showdown slates.

	CPT POSITION:				
	QUARTERBACK				
	FLEX UTILIZATION RATE:				
	QB	RB	WR/TE	K	DST
Same team		0.50	1.82	0.21	0.19
Opposition	0.52	0.48	1.07	0.17	0.05

Carrying a 1.5x salary and DraftKings point multiplier, pinpointing the optimal CPT is a necessity for showdown profitability. For this exercise, let’s assume we’ve already correctly identified the slate-winning CPT and move down to our remaining five FLEX positions to appropriately build out the rest of this lineup. The data above, taken from the past three seasons’ worth

of primetime showdown slates, is for top-1% finishing lineups in the large-field GPP on DraftKings. This particular heat map shows that if a QB is rostered at CPT, he's paired with 1.82 WR/TE from his own team and 1.07 WR/TE from the opposing team, on average. Let's dive in further:

- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (2) same-team WR/TE in 46.3% of top-1% finishing lineups**
- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (3) same-team WR/TE in 18.9% of top-1% finishing lineups**
- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (1) same-team WR/TE in 28.9% of top-1% finishing lineups**
- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (0) same-team WR/TE in 5.1% of top-1% finishing lineups**

Ultimately, the most common winning CPT QB stack is also the most intuitive one. IF a QB is going to finish as the slate's top overall scorer, THEN he's likely supporting multiple pass catchers. Our baseline for CPT QB lineups should default to pairing him with at least (2) WR/TE teammates and adjust on a slate-by-slate basis as needed.

Massaging rules to fit slate context is important, to avoid grouping ourselves out of quality lineups. QBs who derive at least *some* of their value on the ground can be more profitably single stacked or in rare instances played unstacked entirely. There were (8) QBs last season who appeared in at least 10 games and had a rushing share north of 20.0%. These types have more outs to slate-winning fantasy production while supporting fewer pass catchers.

Given DraftKings' full-point PPR format with 100-yard bonuses, if a winning lineup features a quarterback and just one wide receiver, it's more likely we

find the WR to be the optimal CPT while his QB fills a FLEX spot. However, instances where a CPT QB is optimal with just (1) WR are quite common, even for those QBs who lack rushing upside. This can occur even when a QB scores fewer points than his WR if he's the cheaper of the two, if the remaining pass-catching production is evenly distributed behind the top-scoring WR, *or* if the combined WR salaries don't allow for two of them to be rostered together.

- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (1) same-team RB in 44.0% of top-1% finishing lineups**

While some more so than others, we know running backs are positively correlated with their quarterbacks and can conclude that a slate-winning performance from a QB likely means his offense was productive as a whole.

- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (1) opposing WR/TE in 54.4% of top-1% finishing lineups**
- **CPT QBs are paired with exactly (2) opposing WR/TE in 23.5% of top-1% finishing lineups**

Another traditional and widely accepted main-slate stacking strategy, the pass-catching 'bring-back' from the opposing team has been profitable in single-game slates as well. 79.7% of all top-1% finishing lineups that roster a CPT QB have been paired with at least one WR/TE from the opponent. While still not a rigid rule that needs to be enforced, we should often default to rostering a bring-back in our CPT QB lineups.

- CPT QBs are paired with the kicker from their team more often (21.5%) than they're paired with an opposing kicker (17.5%)

The data suggests pairing a CPT QB with *his* kicker is better than an opposing kicker when presented with those two options. For some of the same reasons we would expect skill-position players to outscore baseline expectations if their QB is having a captain-worthy performance, a kicker would benefit from additional scoring opportunities.

CPT POSITION:		FLEX UTILIZATION RATE:				
		QB	RB	WR/TE	K	DST
Same team		0.61	0.12	1.14	0.31	0.25
Opposition		0.59	0.52	1.23	0.18	0.07

- CPT RBs are paired with their QB in 60.8% of top-1% finishing lineups
- CPT RBs are paired with exactly (0) same-team WR/TE in 16.7% of top-1% finishing lineups
- CPT RBs are paired with exactly (1) same-team WR/TE in 55.4% of top-1% finishing lineups
- CPT RBs are paired with exactly (2) same-team WR/TE in 24.6% of top-

1% finishing lineups

No surprises here as we see double WR/TE in FLEX drop from 49.4% with a CPT QB to just 27.7% when an RB is rostered in that position and (3) WR/TE drops from 17.8% to a nearly invisible 3.0%. An ‘*at most (2) same-team WR/TE IF CPT RB*’ rule is acceptable with an ability to adjust when slate-specific dynamics call for it.

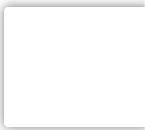
- CPT RBs are rostered as part of 3-3 (3 same team – 3 opponent) lineups in 36.3% of top-1% finishing lineups
- CPT RBs are rostered as part of 4-2 (4 same team – 2 opponent) lineups in 34.2% of top-1% finishing lineups

CPT POSITION:

WIDE RECEIVER

	FLEX UTILIZATION RATE:				
	QB	RB	WR/TE	K	DST
Same team	0.86	0.52	0.75	0.25	0.17
Opposition	0.52	0.50	1.15	0.20	0.08

- CPT WRs are paired with (0) same-team WR/TE in 38.1% of top-1% finishing lineups



- **CPT WRs are paired with (1) same-team WR/TE in 50.4% of top-1% finishing lineups**

Just 9.2% of the time will you find a top-1% finishing lineup that has a CPT WR and two or more pass catchers from his own team in FLEX positions. Most often, we should be implementing an *'IF CPT WR, at most (1) same-team WR/TE'* rule to avoid cannibalizing the upside of our captain selection. Should we find ourselves landing on lineups that include a CPT WR with multiple pass catchers from his own team, the prudent move may be to change our captain to that team's QB to fully capture the passing attack's upside.

- **CPT WRs are paired with at least (1) opposing WR/TE in 83.7% of top-1% finishing lineups**

To an even higher degree than CPT QBs, pass-catching bring-backs from the opposing team in CPT WR lineups are frequent. 54.4% of the time, they include just a single bring-back.

- **CPT WRs are rostered without their QB in 13.9% of top-1% finishing lineups**

We know that historically, it's taken an average of 22.4 DraftKings points, before the 1.5x multiplier, for a WR to finish as the CPT in top-1% finishing lineups. How, then, is it possible for QBs to fall short of those lineups so frequently? The most obvious example is when a single WR soaks up a vast majority of the team's pass-catching production while his QB struggles to produce fantasy points elsewhere. This will occur most often with high-volume, low-aDOT receivers whose production is elevated by DraftKings' scoring system.

Salary constraints are another driver of the unstacked CPT WR success rate. Historically, the average salary, after the 1.5x multiplier, of a CPT WR in top-1% lineups is \$12,550. We also know that the average salary for a starting QB is \$10,647. With at least (1) QB appearing in 92.5% of ALL top-1% lineups, we can confidently assume most winning lineups will feature at least one of the two playable options. However, if the opposing QB matches or exceeds the fantasy production of the wide receiver's quarterback, it can quickly become difficult to find the salary needed to play all three. In these instances, we'll find the opposing QB in winning lineups.

In order to maximize our win potential in naked CPT WR lineups, it makes sense to a) prioritize the opposing team's QB and b) mute the need to play the same-team WR/TE in FLEX.

CPT POSITION:					
TIGHT END					
FLEX UTILIZATION RATE:					
	QB	RB	WR/TE	K	DST
Same team	0.89	0.58	0.81	0.20	0.14
Opposition	0.60	0.53	1.05	0.15	0.06

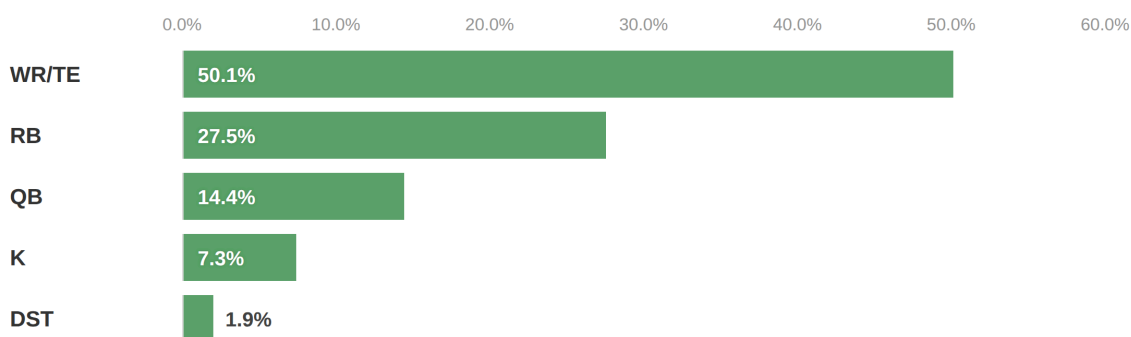
- CPT TEs are paired with their QB in 89.4% of top-1% finishing lineups
- CPT TEs are paired with exactly (1) same-team WR/TE in 58.4% of top-1% finishing lineups

The TE position can largely be treated similarly to their WR peers with the exception of a few who break the traditional tight end mold. The biggest —

and I use that term loosely — differences here include a slightly higher correlation with their QB when compared to CPT WR, mostly as a result of TEs finding a ceiling via touchdowns instead of volume. Touchdown scoring being a huge driver of their fantasy production also means more opportunities for fellow pass catchers to rack up PPR-friendly production, making them more likely to be rostered alongside a CPT TE than we'd expect for a CPT WR.

Frequency of 'Bring Back' in Top-1% finishing 5-1 or 1-5 lineups

5-1 and 1-5 lineups refer to rosters that include (5) players from a single team with just (1) player rostered from the opponent



Let's shift gears from optimally building around our preferred CPT to optimally building around a preferred outcome. Onslaught lineups, as I'll refer to them, include *five* players from one team with just *one* player from the opposing team. A possible way to build for blowouts or just lopsided fantasy production, onslaughts are generally less utilized than more balanced roster constructions and, at least in my opinion, have relatively straightforward paths to climbing leaderboards when we're right, and we can start by knocking out the bring-back from the opposing side.

- **50.1% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use a WR/TE from the opposing team**

- **94.7% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use a CPT from the onslaught (5) side**

Pretty straightforward, right? We most likely want to be considering a pass catcher *or* the occasional running back to fill out the opposing side of our onslaught and we DO NOT want to roster them at CPT. While fully understanding exceptions exist, we almost always want our CPT to come from the onslaught side, as a bet on 5-1 winning is a bet on lopsided outcomes.

Now on to the other side of the ball:

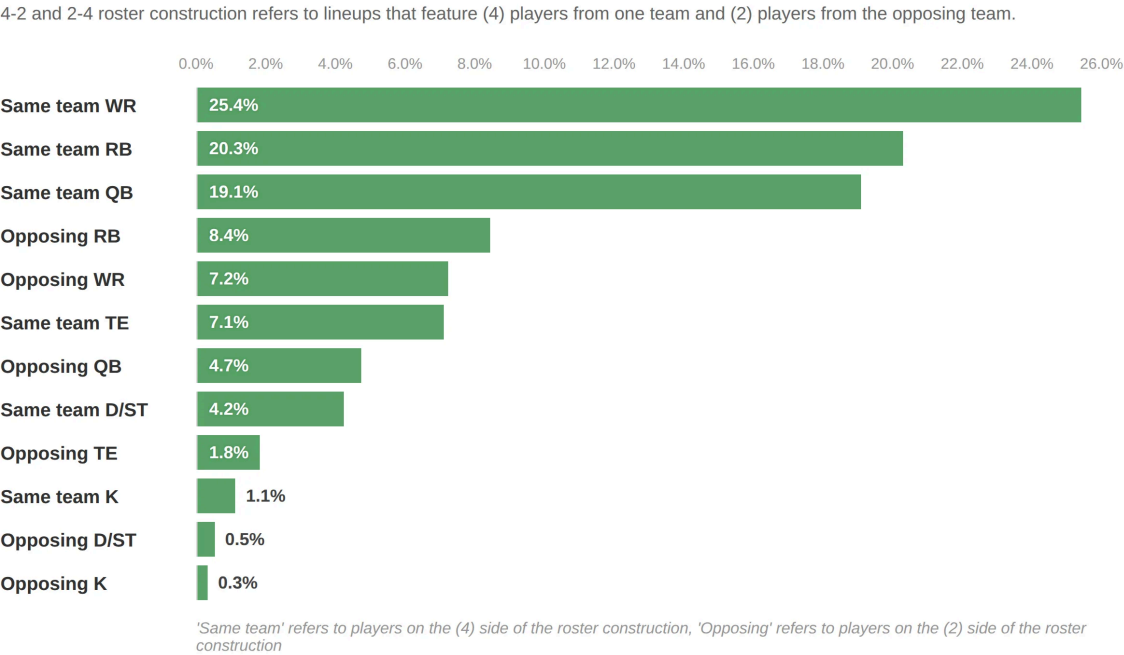
- **95.1% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use the QB from the onslaught side**
- **28.3% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use CPT QB from the onslaught side**
- **47.3% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use exactly (2) WR/TE from the onslaught side**
- **67.8% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use exactly (1) RB from the onslaught side**
- **58.4% of top-1% finishing onslaught lineups use the D/ST from the onslaught side**

We should almost always be including the QB from the onslaught side in our 5-1 lineups. If one team produces enough DraftKings points to propel this

many players into a winning lineup, it’s extremely likely the QB scored enough raw points to also be in that group. Additionally, they’re the most likely CPT in 5-1 constructions (28.4%) just ahead of WR (28.3%), RB (21.9%), and D/ST (13.6%).

While CPT D/ST only appears in 3.3% of all other top-1% finishing lineup constructions (2-4, 3-3, 4-2), they force their way into a rather impressive 13.6% of top-1% finishing 5-1 and 1-5 lineups. If an offense is going to support (4) skill-position players and limit the opposition to (1) FLEX-worthy performance, it’s possible the salary relief earned from rostering the onslaught D/ST at CPT is deserving of our consideration (ducks).

Frequency of CPT Position in Top-1% finishing 4-2 or 2-4 Roster Constructions



- 77.1% of top-1% finishing lineups roster a CPT from the (4) side in 4-2/2-4 roster construction

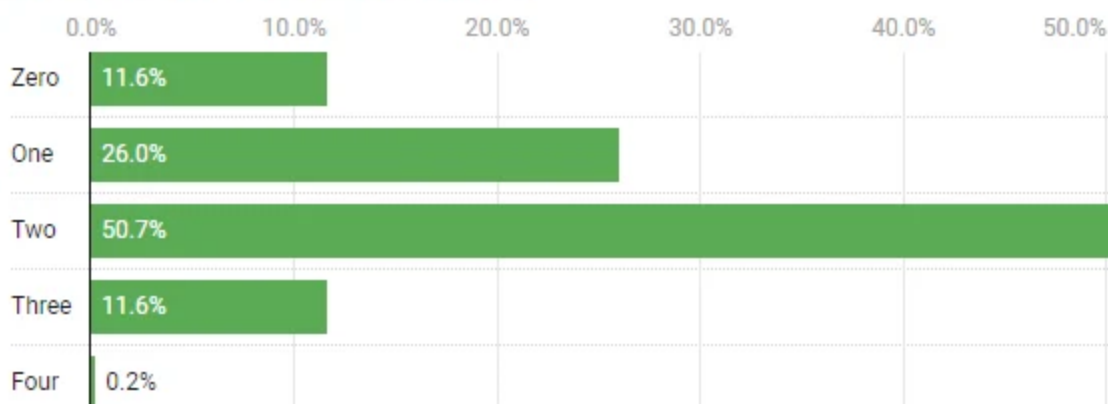
Not quite as drastic as the 94.7% in the 5-1/1-5 lineups discussed above, but the same general thesis holds true in 2-4/4-2 roster constructions as well. Of course, it's possible a WR or RB from the opposing team separates in a big enough way to finish as the optimal CPT, but it's much more likely that our CPT comes from the side we're heavier on in these types of unbalanced builds.

- **69.4% of top-1% finishing 4-2/2-4 lineups use exactly (1) WR/TE from the opposing team**
- **10.4% of top-1% finishing 4-2/2-4 lineups use exactly (2) WR/TE from the opposing team**
- **43.2% of top-1% finishing 4-2/2-4 lineups use exactly (1) RB from the opposing team**

Not unlike the 5-1/1-5 roster construction, the most common bring-back from the opposing side of a 4-2 lineup will be a skill-position player who doesn't rely on the overall success of his offense to produce fantasy points. We should infrequently be considering opposing D/ST (4.4%) and/or opposing kicker (11.4%) as pieces of the two-player bring-back in these lineups.

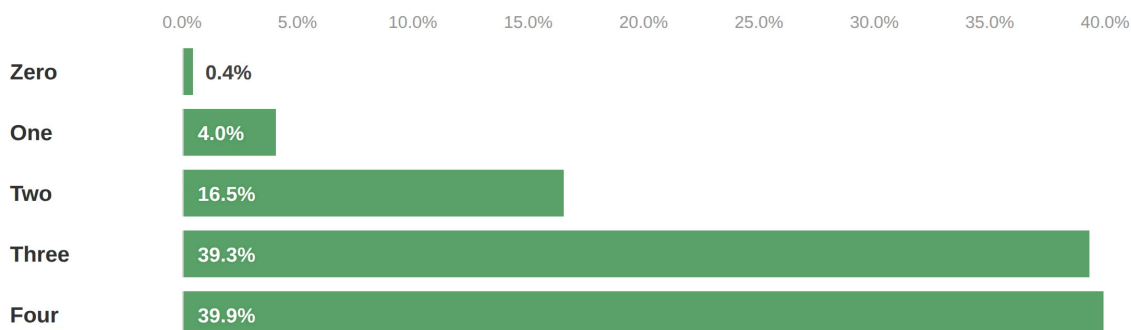
How many WR/TE Rostered With CPT Rushing QB

Rushing QB refers to any quarterback with at least a 20.0% share of the team's rushing attempts over the duration of a full season



Above, we stressed how important it is to relax our rules based on slate-specific context. Last season, there were (8) QBs with at least a 20.0% share of their team's rushing attempts, presenting us with at least a handful of signal-callers who can provide fantasy upside with more than just their arm. For QBs that fit this archetype, we see the frequency of them being rostered unstacked at CPT increase to 11.6% vs. just 5.6% for their pocket-passing counterparts. While single- and double-stack success rate remains largely unchanged, we also witness fewer successful triple stacks (11.6%) vs. 17.8% for QBs with a sub-20% rush share.

How Many Teammates are Rostered Alongside D/ST in Top-1% Finishing Lineups



Many showdown correlations are neat and easily explainable, like CPT QB + FLEX WR/TE, but when we get to D/ST and kicker, lines are blurred, and figuring out how to best build lineups with these positions in them becomes more difficult. While there is no one-size-fits-all solution, we can try and avoid common mistakes to maximize our upside when these positions do find their way into winning lineups.

- **D/STs are paired with 3.14 teammates on average**
- **D/STs are paired with exactly (3) teammates in 39.3% of top-1% finishing lineups**
- **D/STs are paired with exactly (4) teammates in 39.9% of top-1% finishing lineups**

Beyond the clear confirmation that D/STs should not be used as the lone bring-back in 5-1 lineups (0.4%), we can see that even as part of the two-player side in 4-2 lineups (4.0%), opposing D/STs struggle to find winning lineups. In fact, 79.2% of all top-1% finishing lineups that feature a D/ST pair the defense with at least *three* additional teammates.

Future Analysis

Going forward, I hope to maintain this column as an ever-updating repository of sorts that we can all use on Thursday, Sunday, and Monday nights when crafting unblemished showdown lineups. In turn, I'll need your help to let me know what I've missed and what additional information could be added to further improve our chances of climbing primetime leaderboards.



Bryce Young, Carolina Panthers, DraftKings, FanDuel, DFS Strategy, In-Season Package, Showdown



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